

Senior Geography Project

Transportation and its effects on housing in Waterloo and Alexandria



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Introduction



Figure 1: Map of Waterloo, Alexandria and Waterloo Metro Station (Redfern News, n.d.)

The investigation aims to investigate the effect of the Waterloo Metro Station and Sydney Metro City M1 Line on the surrounding localities of Waterloo and Alexandria. The Sydney Metro City M1 Line is a \$21.6 billion new major underground transportation corridor connecting existing heavy rail infrastructure at Chatswood and Sydenham, via the Central Business District (CBD). The Metro aims to reduce congestion and improve public transport efficiency and connectivity in the Sydney region, by connecting northwest Sydney to southwest Sydney via the CBD. According to Transport for NSW, the M1 line will promote urban renewal and deliver new integrated housing and commercial development.

Geographically, the M1 City section serves suburbs between Chatswood and Sydenham in a linear north-south alignment. The Waterloo Metro station is situated between the suburbs of Alexandria and Waterloo and further serves the office business cluster of South Eveleigh. The suburb of Waterloo has a population of 16,379 possesses a high concentration of public and social housing, whilst Alexandria remains an expensive inner-city suburb with mainly private terrace houses and small apartments present, with a lower population and higher median income.

Aims and hypotheses

Aims:

1. to investigate how land usage and building development in Waterloo has changed since the construction of the Metro
2. to examine how gentrification has changed since the announcement and construction of the Metro
3. to assess relevant stakeholder perceptions of how the Metro has influenced the local area

Hypotheses:

1. increased transit-oriented development has led to densification of building development, and potential loss of social housing.
2. increased gentrification has been caused by the Metro, leading to increased housing prices and household incomes in the region
3. the Metro has been received positively by local residents due to enhancements in transport connectivity, and has been supported by the Government, contractors, and local businesses

Methodology

The aims of the geographical report were investigated through both primary and secondary research regarding the Sydney Metro Waterloo station. Primary data was collected through photographic observation, and short interviews with individuals at the Waterloo station. 10 individuals were surveyed on the platform of Waterloo Metro station, and asked questions such as “Do you live in the local area?”, “How has the introduction of the Metro provided benefit to you”, and “Do you think that demographics have shifted/increased gentrification has occurred since the construction of the Metro?”. The interviews specifically aimed to address the perspectives of local stakeholders on the effectiveness of the Metro and perceptions on changing gentrification or demographics in the area. Additionally, photographic research of key sites and surrounding areas of the Waterloo/Alexandria area allowed for further analysis of changes in building development type. Photographs taken and summaries of interview results are included as figures and tables in this report.

Secondary data was collected from a range of government publications, planning documents, transport reports, and media sources. Spatial and planning information was obtained from Sydney Metro planning and project reports, NSW Government urban renewal documents, and City of Sydney publications to investigate the intended impacts and outcomes of the Waterloo Metro station and surrounding development. Property statistics and housing development information was obtained

from government sources and housing market research institutions to examine trends occurring before and after the opening of the Metro. News articles and academic publications were utilised to provide context regarding redevelopment projects, public housing renewal, stakeholder perspectives and debates surrounding gentrification in Waterloo. The secondary sources were thus analysed in conjunction with primary data collected during fieldwork to evaluate the extent that the Sydney Metro has influenced urban development and socioeconomic change within Alexandria and Waterloo.

Research Findings

The Sydney Metro City line is a transportation project aimed at improving reliability and capacity overall in the Sydney rail network (Transport for NSW, n.d), through the bypassing of existing heavy rail bottlenecks on the City Circle and Sydney Harbour Bridge railway lines.

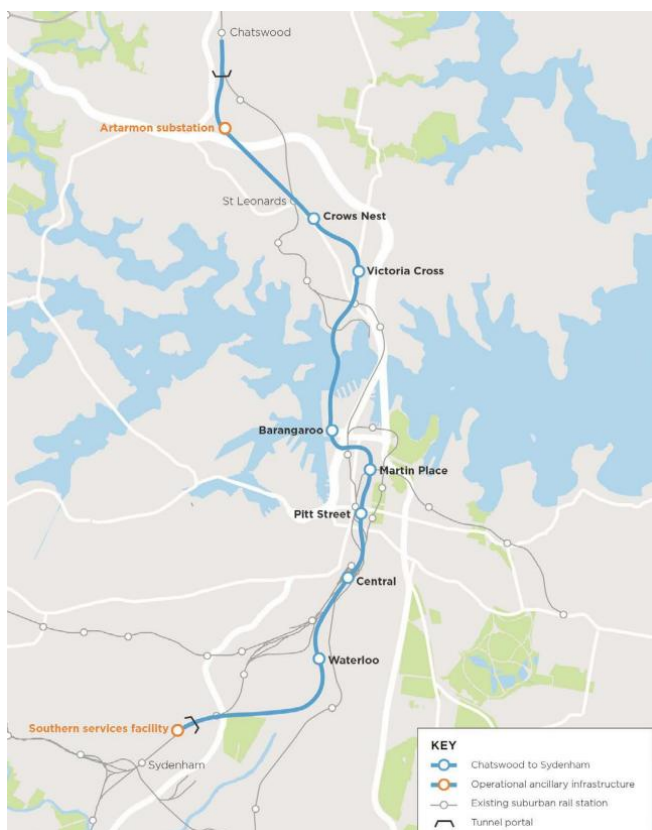


Figure 2: Map of the Sydney Metro City segment from Chatswood to Sydenham (Transport for NSW, n.d.)

Additionally, all Sydney Metro projects aim to function as a catalyst for urban renewal and decentralisation, aligning with the "Greater Sydney Region Plan" to create a more connected, polycentric city (Greater Sydney Commission, 2018). At the Metro station location of Waterloo, many developmental changes have occurred, or are planned to occur in accordance to the Waterloo Renewal Project and Waterloo Metro Quarter project. Many agencies are involved in the delivery of the Waterloo Metro station and surrounding developments, including Transport for NSW, Metro

Trains Sydney, John Holland Group, Mirvac Group, City of Sydney Council, NSW Housing Delivery Authority, Stockland, Link Wentworth Housing, City West Housing and Birribee Housing.

Aim 1 - to investigate how land usage and building development in Waterloo has changed since the construction of the Metro



Figure 3 (left): View of Waterloo Metro station site from Botany Road in December 2015 (Google Maps, 2015)

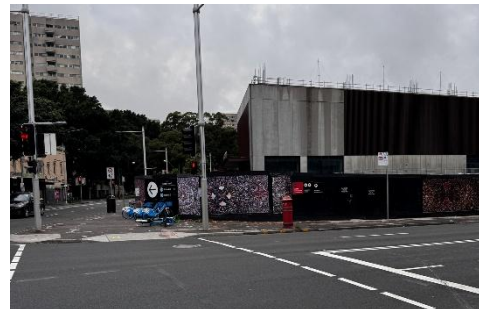


Figure 4 (right): View of Waterloo Metro station site from Botany Road in June 2026



Figure 5 (left): View of Waterloo Metro station location from Raglan St in September 2016 (Google Maps, 2016)



Figure 6 (right): View of Waterloo Metro station entrance from Raglan in June 2026

Prior to the Metro construction, the block which the station is situated was previously zoned for commercial purposes exclusively, with no housing. As evident in Figure 3 and Figure 5, small businesses such as the “SAM CONVENIENCE STORE” and “O’MULLANES PHARMACY” along

Raglan St from Botany Rd to Cope St previously operated in Waterloo. The businesses were removed as a result of the Metro construction, and have not been replaced as of June 2026, evident in Figure 5 and 6. At the corner of Botany Rd and Raglan St, no building is present in 2026, however in accordance to the Waterloo Station Precinct Plan (figure A1-5), a commercial zoned tower is under construction (Sydney Metro, 2022).

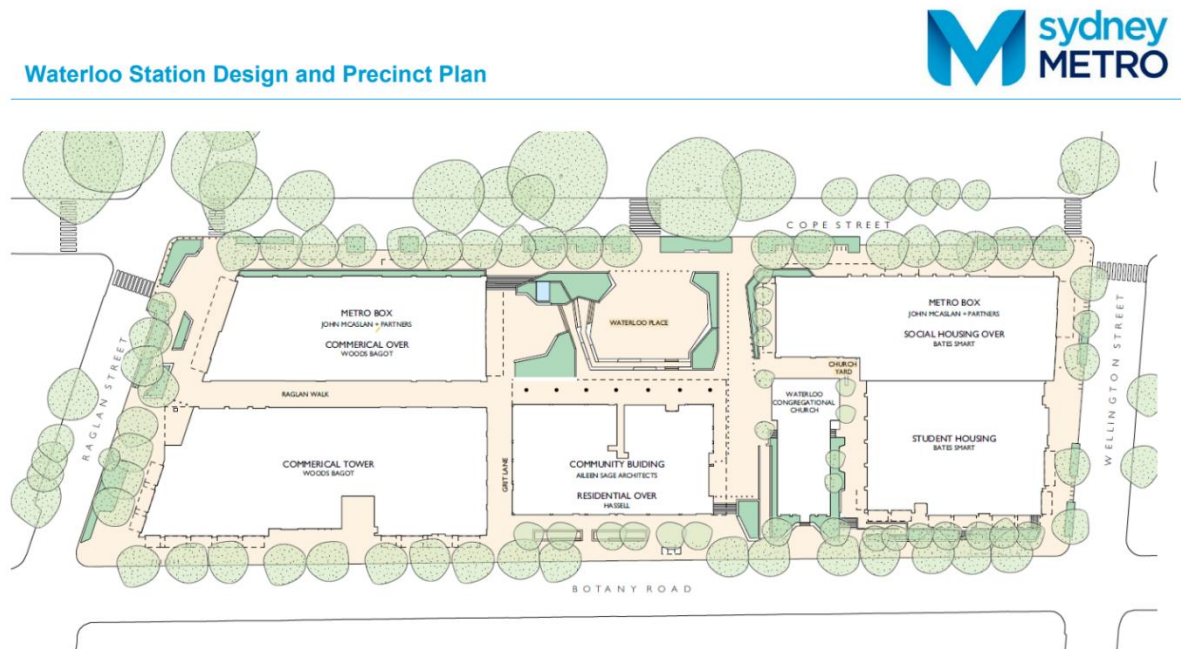


Figure 7: Future precinct site plan of Waterloo Metro station (Sydney Metro, 2022)



Figure 8 (left): New medium rise developments of student accommodation and public housing

Figure 9 (right): Existing public housing estate in Waterloo (Bing Maps, 2026)

As of June 2026, limited other changes to building development have occurred, due to construction delays of both the Metro project and surrounding renewal plans. As the Metro station was constructed on commercially zoned land, no public housing was lost as a result of its construction. All existing buildings, excluding the Waterloo congregational church on the block bounded by Cope St, Raglan St, Botany Rd and Wellington St were demolished, however only two new buildings in addition to the station has since been constructed. According to visual observation and 3D imagery from Bing Maps (Figure 9), it can be observed that the existing Waterloo housing estate remains unmodified since the construction of the Metro.

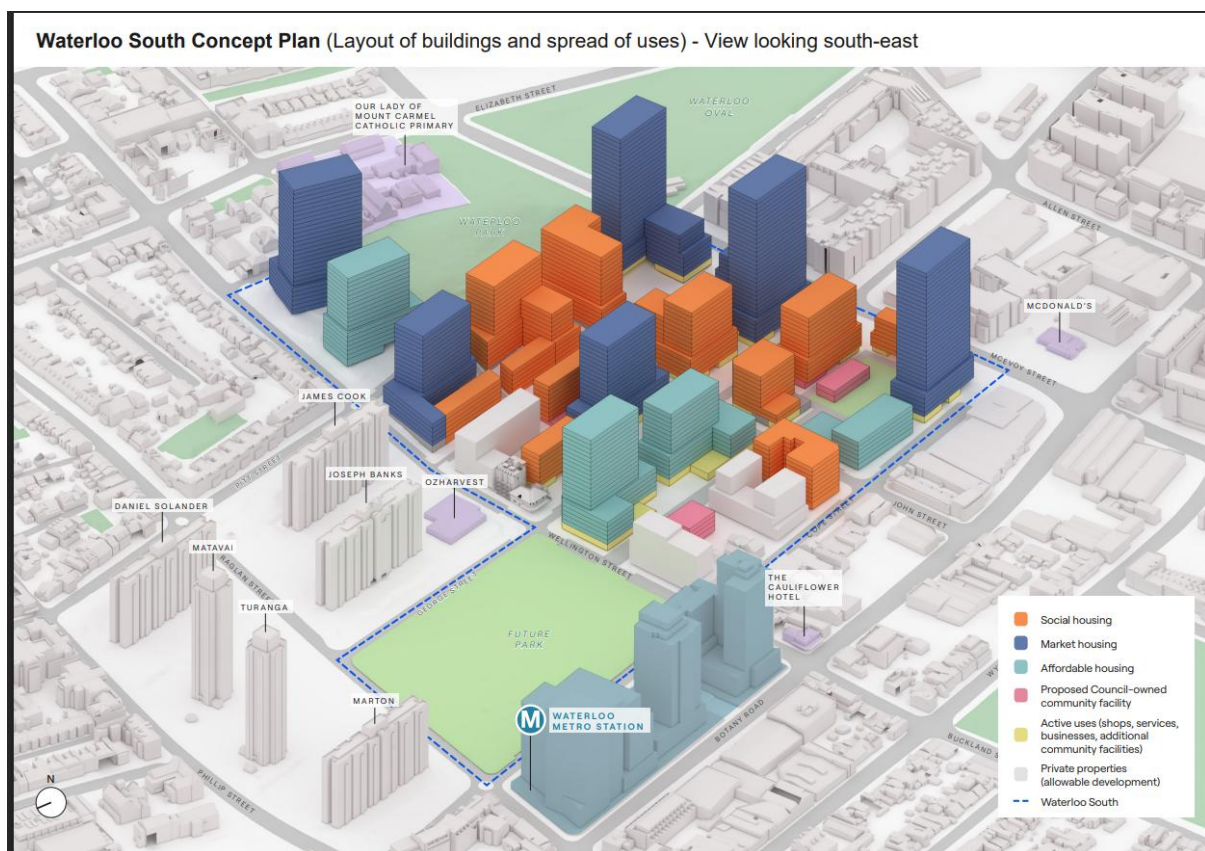


Figure 10: planned Waterloo south developments (Waterloo Partnership, 2021)

However, due to the Waterloo Precinct Renewal and Waterloo Metro Quarter projects, new medium-high density development is expected to be constructed within the area, specifically in Waterloo. The Waterloo South development consists of numerous housing and commercial structures being developed in the southeast of the Waterloo Metro station, resulting in the demolition of many public housing units currently located in this area.



Figure 11: Protests at Waterloo regarding the removal of public housing (Bowring, 2026)

Advocacy groups such as Action for Public Housing protested the destruction of existing public housing units, and instead supported ongoing refurbishment instead of complete redevelopment. Police intervention was required to remove protestors, and thus initial demolition will begin within one month. Whilst the Waterloo Renewal Project and Waterloo Metro Quarter plans will not be fully realised for the foreseeable future, it is evidence that land use and density changes will be occurring in the future to support transit-oriented development following the construction of the Sydney Metro City.

Aim 2 - to examine how gentrification has changed since the announcement and construction of the Metro in Waterloo and Alexandria

Gentrification refers to the process by which higher-income residents move into a traditionally lower-income area, often resulting in rising property values, displacement of long-term residents, and shifts in the demographic and cultural character of a locality (Atkinson, 2004). Waterloo and Alexandria have historically been working class industrial suburbs, with significant proportions of social housing, especially in Waterloo. The evidence gathered through both quantitative property data and qualitative interviews suggests that gentrification in these suburbs has occurred independently of the Metro, as part of a broader, long-term trend of inner-Sydney urban renewal.

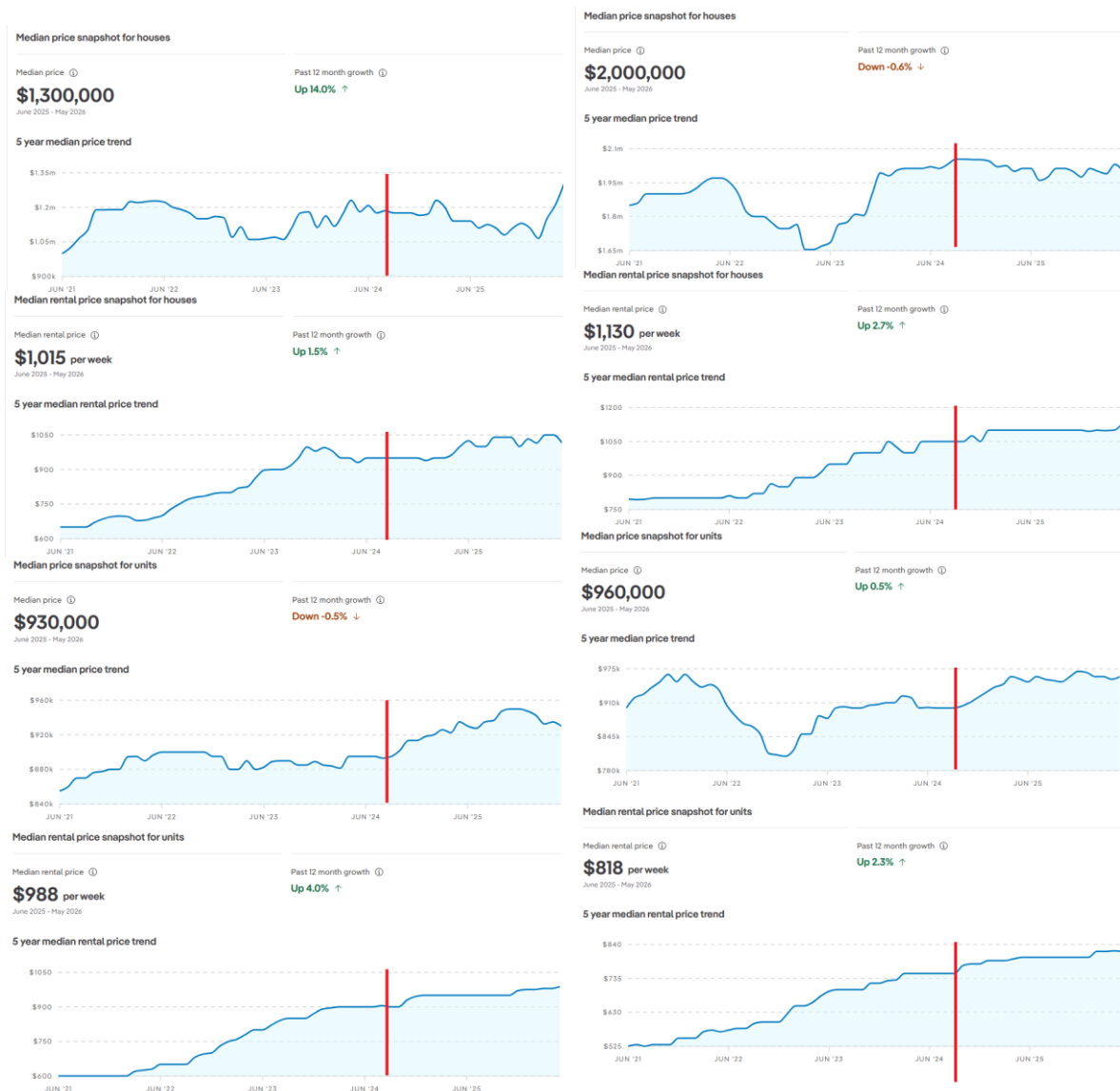


Figure 12 (left): Compilation of median price and rental price for houses and units in Waterloo over the past 5 years, with a red line marked at the opening of the Metro (REA Group, 2026)

Figure 13 (right): Compilation of median price and rental price for houses and units in Alexandria over the past 5 years, with a red line marked at the opening of the Metro (REA Group, 2026)

Figures 12 and 13 display the median sale and rental prices for houses and units in Waterloo and Alexandria over the past five years, with the opening of the Waterloo Metro station marked in red. In Waterloo and Alexandria it was evident that since the opening of the Metro, the purchase price of units increased over the following 3 months. However, other indicators for unit rental price, house rental price and house purchase price indicate the Metro had no significant impact on house pricing, especially in line with 5 year trends.

In Waterloo, the median house price rose from approximately \$1.8 million in June 2021 to \$2,000,000 in June 2026. Median weekly rent for houses rose from approximately \$800 in 2021 to \$1,130 in

2026, an increase of over 40%. Unit prices similarly increased from a low of approximately \$800,000 in 2022 to \$960,000 in 2026, while unit rents climbed from \$575 to \$818 per week. The increasing price trend is visible consistently across the entire five-year period, beginning significantly before the opening of the Metro in 2025, indicating that gentrification pressures were already firmly established prior to the Metro's introduction. In Alexandria, the median house price grew from approximately \$1.0 million in 2021 to \$1,300,000 in 2026, a 30% increase. Median house rents grew from approximately \$650 to \$1,015 per week, and unit rents rose from approximately \$620 to \$988 per week. Additionally, Alexandria's larger distance from the Metro catchment area would suggest broader economic factors have resulted in gentrification in the area, as otherwise Waterloo would likely have seen a significantly larger increase in housing prices due to proximity to the Metro.

Table 1: Table of results from individuals interviewed on platform of Waterloo Metro Station regarding perception of gentrification and demographics in the local area

Interviewee	From local area?	Perspective on the Metro's effect on gentrification and demographics
1	Yes	Unsure
2	Yes	Gentrification was already happening, not because of the Metro
3	Yes	Would probably cause gentrification, could provide some benefit to the area.
4	Yes	Gentrification already happened.
5	Newly moved to Waterloo	Gentrification increasing due to removal of social housing towers in the vicinity of the station
6	No	*
7	Yes	Increased diversity of people in Waterloo as a result of the Metro
8	Yes	Not much change to demographics as a result of the Metro
9	Yes	Did not notice any increase in gentrification apart from some house price increases
10	No	*

Additionally, according to interviews with users of the Waterloo Metro station, individuals such as Interviewee 2 and Interviewee 4 similarly stated that any gentrification likely occurred not as a result of the construction of the Metro, and instead had already been occurring in the area. The house pricing data also supports Interviewee 9's observation of some price increases over time. However, Interviewee 5 believes gentrification is more influenced by the overall Waterloo urban renewal, resulting in the destruction of social housing, thus attributing some cause to the Metro construction.

Aim 3 - to assess relevant stakeholder perceptions of how the Metro has influenced the local area

Many individuals and organisations are stakeholders of the Waterloo Metro station project and surrounding developments, including local and non-local residents, local businesses, Sydney City Council and NSW State Government agencies, the Metro operator, and construction companies. Thus, the Metro project has a wide range of influences on many groups in the local region.

Table 2: Table of results from individuals interviewed on platform of Waterloo Metro Station regarding perception of the Metro.

Interviewee	From local area?	Perspective on the Metro in relation to Waterloo
1	Yes	More accessible and efficient to get to work in Martin Place compared to train
2	Yes	More efficient to get to the city, but already was using Redfern station
3	Yes	Improved north south connection, significantly faster to reach workplace in Victoria Cross
4	Yes	More convenient than bus or train
5	Newly moved to Waterloo	Moved to Waterloo because of the Metro, allows for people to work in different areas of the city.
6	No	Brought more people into Waterloo/Alexandria, improved cross city transport and access to other workplaces
7	Yes	Easier to reach work and university
8	Yes	Very positive impact on the area liveability. Improves access to other areas. Weekend closure of Metro has significant impact on efficiency.
9	Yes	*
10	No	Metro improved access to the city through bus transfer, Metro has been very effective project.

Local and non-local residents generally perceived the Waterloo Metro station positively, particularly in terms of improved accessibility, connectivity and convenience. Of the ten interviewees, eight were

local residents, whilst others used Waterloo station as a connection point from other transportation. Most individuals reported that the Metro had reduced travel times, and Interviewee 1 and Interviewee 3 stated the Metro provided more efficient access to employment centres such as Martin Place and Victoria Cross. Other residents such as Interviewee 7 also noted that the Metro improved connections across Sydney and made commuting to work and university easier, suggesting that the project has enhanced liveability and accessibility within the local area. Interviewee 5 stated that they had recently moved to Waterloo because of the Metro, indicating that improved transport infrastructure may be influencing residential attraction and population change. Non-local residents similarly viewed the Metro favourably, highlighting improved access to Waterloo and better cross-city transport connections. These perceptions suggest that stakeholders largely believe the Metro has had a positive influence on the local area by increasing accessibility, attracting new residents and strengthening Waterloo's integration with the wider Sydney metropolitan region.

While many residents viewed the Metro positively, the broader Waterloo redevelopment has generated significant opposition from some public housing residents and advocacy groups. In June 2026, protesters argued that the Waterloo Renewal Project would displace residents and communities, and reduce the supply of public housing in the area (City Hub, 2026). Conversely, the NSW Government maintained that the project would deliver a greater number of social, affordable, and private dwellings overall (Bowring, 2026). Thus, the protests highlight that stakeholder perceptions of developmental change in Waterloo are not universally positive, as some residents believe redevelopment associated with the Metro and urban renewal pose a threat to community identity and housing security.



Figure 14: Yum Yai (Local business located Botany Rd opposite Waterloo Metro station)

Local businesses have generally benefited from increased accessibility and foot traffic generated by the Metro. Improved connections to employment centres and other parts of Sydney have increased the number of people travelling through Waterloo, creating opportunities for greater customer demand and economic activity. For example, “YUM YAI” Thai restaurant, operating on Botany Rd since approximately 2012 (Figure 14), became significantly busier as a result of the Metro, due to both construction worker activity and other foot traffic. Additionally, the business was able to reinvest in renovations, reflecting how the Metro provides benefit to the local economy and business activity. However, as demonstrated in Figure 3 and Figure 5, some businesses such as the “SAM CONVENIENCE STORE” and “OMULLANES PHARMACY” have been demolished as a result of the construction of the Metro. Therefore, remaining local businesses are likely to perceive the Metro positively because of its potential to support long-term economic growth and urban renewal. State and local government agencies, Metro Trains Sydney, and construction companies, such as Mirvac and John Holland Group, generally perceive the Waterloo Metro Station positively due to transport, economic and urban development objectives. The NSW Government and Sydney City Council believe the Metro aligns with long term masterplans by promoting public transport use, reducing reliance on private vehicles and encouraging transit-oriented development and urban renewal close to the CBD (City of Sydney, 2023). Similarly, Metro Trains Sydney views the station as a catalyst for urban renewal, resulting in increased ridership due to higher population density within the transportation catchment. Construction companies also benefit from the delivery of major infrastructure projects through employment and investment opportunities. Consequently, the government and contractors consider the Metro a successful investment that supports urban renewal and transport connectivity in Waterloo.

Conclusion

In the conclusion analyse the research results and evaluate them in terms of the stated aims and hypotheses. Discuss the ways in which the findings reflected or differed from what was expected. Offer an explanation as to why particular results were achieved and outline any unexpected or interesting outcomes from the research. If appropriate, reflect on the geographical implications of the research.

The investigation aimed to analyse the effect of the Waterloo Metro Station and Sydney Metro City M1 Line on the suburbs of Waterloo and Alexandria.

In order to fulfil the first aim, *to investigate how land usage and building development in Waterloo has changed since the construction of the Metro*, the investigation collated both primary fieldwork

photographic observations and secondary source evidence, including development plans and 3D imagery. The first hypothesis was somewhat supported, as densification of development has occurred through the construction of two new medium-high density buildings for student and social housing at the Waterloo station site, however limited other development has occurred due to delays in the delivery of the Waterloo Metro Quarter and Waterloo Precinct Renewal plans. The hypothesis that social housing may have been removed for the Metro is currently unsupported, as the site of the Metro station was previously occupied by small businesses, however social housing is planned to be demolished following protests in order to continue urban renewal in the suburb of Waterloo.

To satisfy the second aim, *to examine how gentrification has changed since the announcement and construction of the Metro*, the investigation analysed housing market data and local resident perspectives. The second hypothesis was largely unsupported. Although housing prices and rents in both Waterloo and Alexandria have increased over recent years, it was determined the trends predated the Waterloo Metro Station and continued at similar rates afterwards. Whilst some increase in unit sale prices was observed following the opening of the Metro, insufficient evidence was found to conclude that the Metro was the primary cause of rising housing costs in the region. Similar increases in property values and rents in Alexandria, despite greater distance from the station, suggest that broader processes of urban renewal and housing market pressures have caused present gentrification. Interview responses also indicated that many local residents believed gentrification had already occurred or was already underway before the Metro was constructed. Data regarding household incomes was unable to be determined due to lack of relevant Census data from this period. Therefore, whilst the Metro may cause future demographic and socioeconomic change, present gentrification was not caused solely by the construction of the Metro.

To address the third aim, *to assess relevant stakeholder perceptions of how the Metro has influenced the local area*, the investigation examined the views of residents, businesses and organisations associated with the project. The third hypothesis was largely supported as stakeholders believed the Metro has had a positive impact on Waterloo and Alexandria. Most residents interviewed viewed the Metro positively due to improved accessibility, connectivity and reduced travel times, while some indicated it had increased the attractiveness of Waterloo as a place to live. Local businesses have generally benefited from increased foot traffic and economic activity, such as Yum Yai. Additionally, State and local government, Metro Trains Sydney and construction companies support the Metro because the project aligns with transport and urban renewal objectives and provides significant investment return. However, some public housing residents and advocacy groups, such as Action for Public Housing oppose aspects of the broader Waterloo Renewal Project due to concerns about displacement and community impacts. Overall, the Metro has been received positively by most stakeholder groups, supporting the hypothesis.

Evaluation

The SGP provided an opportunity to develop my skills in collecting, analysing and presenting geographic data through an investigation into the impacts of the Waterloo Metro station and Sydney Metro City M1 Line. The project strengthened my ability to integrate primary and secondary research. Obtained through fieldwork observations, interviews, photographic evidence, development plans, property market data, and news reports from reliable sources. The aspect of the project that was the most effective was the interviews at Waterloo station, as I was able to gain direct insight into stakeholders' personal opinions and perceptions of the Metro. This data was able to be compared with quantitative secondary data regarding property prices and other land development concerns. If given the opportunity to improve the investigation I would increase the sample size of interviews conducted at Waterloo Metro station to obtain a broader range of stakeholder perspectives and improve the reliability of findings. Additionally, the investigation would benefit from improved access to spatial socioeconomic data, regarding household income and demographics, to more effectively assess the extent of gentrification in Alexandria and Waterloo. Due to the latest Census data being released for 2021, relevant socioeconomic information could not be collated and thus limited the effectiveness of the investigation. Therefore, the project utilised a range of primary and secondary sources to evaluate the impacts of the Metro on Waterloo and Alexandria, and could be extended further by conducting more interviews and obtaining new socioeconomic data

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Appendix

Table 1: Table of results from individuals interviewed on platform of Waterloo Metro Station regarding perception of gentrification and demographics in the local area

Interviewee	From local area?	Perspective on the Metro's effect on gentrification and demographics
1	Yes	Unsure
2	Yes	Gentrification was already happening, not because of the Metro
3	Yes	Would probably cause gentrification, could provide some benefit to the area.
4	Yes	Gentrification already happened.
5	Newly moved to Waterloo	Gentrification increasing due to removal of social housing towers in the vicinity of the station
6	No	*
7	Yes	Increased diversity of people in Waterloo as a result of the Metro
8	Yes	Not much change to demographics as a result of the Metro
9	Yes	Did not notice any increase in gentrification apart from some house price increases
10	No	*

Table 2: Table of results from individuals interviewed on platform of Waterloo Metro Station regarding perception of the Metro.

Interviewee	From local area?	Perspective on the Metro in relation to Waterloo
1	Yes	More accessible and efficient to get to work in Martin Place compared to train
2	Yes	More efficient to get to the city, but already was using Redfern station
3	Yes	Improved north south connection, significantly faster to reach workplace in Victoria Cross
4	Yes	More convenient than bus or train
5	Newly moved to Waterloo	Moved to Waterloo because of the Metro, allows for people to work in different areas of the city.

6	No	Brought more people into Waterloo/Alexandria, improved cross city transport and access to other workplaces
7	Yes	Easier to reach work and university
8	Yes	Very positive impact on the area liveability. Improves access to other areas. Weekend closure of Metro has significant impact on efficiency.
9	Yes	*
10	No	Metro improved access to the city through bus transfer, Metro has been very effective project.